



User's Manual: **Oxford Drive** for pedal version 2

Thank you for making sounds with one of our Oxford Drive pedals! This manual should tell you everything that you need to know in order to take full advantage of the features of the pedal, but if you have any questions feel free to email us at thekingofgear@gmail.com.

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What's different about the Oxford Drive V2?

The earliest Oxford Drive pedals were released in early-2019. Those pedals offered two clipping modes (Si and LED) and had a standard true bypass switch. Some of the earliest pedals had an oscillation problem at high gain and volume, caused by the the wiring of the bypass switch. Re-wiring the switch solves the problem. In early-2020, we added a third clipping mode (asymmetrical). Pedals with the added clipping mode are otherwise identical to the pedals from 2019, even using the same PCB with just a small modification for the 3-position toggle switch. So we decided not to call it a new version. These pedals sold for \$170 USD.

The Oxford Drive version 2 was released in late-2021. Two major features were added to the pedal: a flexible soft-touch bypass and a new voice switch. Internally, the pedal has a totally redesigned circuit board for lower noise. It also has high quality C0G capacitors, which will prevent the occasional microphonic issues experienced by some early Oxford Drive pedals. While all of those improvements have increased the price of the pedal a bit, we think they're well worth it to create what we consider the perfect version of this pedal.

Technical Info

The Oxford Drive requires 9V DC power from a standard 2.1mm center-negative plug (Boss-style). Current draw is ~8mA. The pedal will work fine on a daisy-chain, but to reduce potential sources of noise or hum we recommend using the pedal with an isolated power supply or with its own power adapter. There is no battery option. The pedal uses a 1590B-style enclosure. Dimensions (with knobs) are 60mm (W) x 115mm (D) x 53mm (H).

Signal Placement

The general rule for distortion pedals is that they should be placed after wah, fuzz, compressor, pitch-shifter, and effects, and that they should be placed prior to volume, modulation, delay, and reverb effects. That said, there are many reasons to make exceptions to these rules. Different modulation pedals sound better before or after distortion effects. Intense phasers often sound better before distortion, while subtle phasers often sound better after distortion. Placing a volume pedal after the Oxford Drive will allow you to control your overall volume/level, while placing a volume pedal before the Oxford Drive will allow you to control the amount of gain/distortion. A huge variety of washy, wall-of-sound tones can be created by placing reverb and delay before distortion. In general, it's worth experimenting with a variety of settings and signal placements in order to find what works best for your particular signal chain. The extra modes on the Oxford Drive allow it to perform as an overdrive in addition to a distortion, so you may want to place it prior to any dedicated distortion pedals.

In the case of our own Mini Glitch pedal, we recommend placing the Mini Glitch before the Oxford drive if you want more ambient glitch sounds (especially if you use the threshold mode). But placing the Mini Glitch after the Oxford Drive will allow for more aggressive and disorienting glitch sounds.

Tips

The first thing to keep in mind when using this pedal is that the “contour” control is not a “mid” control. Contour controls both the treble and the mid frequencies. In low contour settings, the pedal is mid-focused with reduced treble. In high contour settings, the pedal is mid-scooped with much more treble available. This makes a very wide range of settings available, more than most people realize, but you’ll generally need to adjust the bass and treble whenever you adjust the contour. The bass control is logarithmic, so to reduce bass you’ll need to set it pretty low. Don’t be afraid of extremely knob settings with this pedal, as they are often necessary to coax the best sounds from it.

Second, this pedal is not a true Marshall-In-A-Box pedal. It is certainly Marshall-ish, but it isn’t a reproduction of an amp circuit and it doesn’t sound like any particular amp. It really has a sound of its own – and it definitely can’t be described as “transparent”. One reason for that is the pedal’s inherent filtering. Just like on a popular green overdrive pedal, both the treble and bass frequencies are heavily filtered, regardless of knob positions. And just like that popular overdrive, the filtering allows the pedal to cut through and occupy a very specific space in the mix. In general, this pedal will sound best in a loud band mix.

Additionally, the filtering makes the pedal sound good with synthesizers and other instruments with rich harmonic overtones, since it prevents the distortion from becoming harsh and buzzy even with complex inputs.

The third thing to keep in mind is that this circuit is most popularly used through a totally clean Fender-style amp. It certainly can sound good through a variety of amps, but the pedal settings that work with a clean amp won’t necessarily work through a dirty amp, and vice-versa. A clean amp, especially a solid-state amp, are optimal for achieving an extremely focused tone with a lot of definition. But the extra volume available from the Oxford Drive (especially in LED and asym modes) make it great as an overdrive pedal too. But you’ll probably want to lower both the gain and the bass if you’re pushing dirty amps or other dirt pedals into heavier distortion.

Flexible True Bypass

The Oxford Drive's flexible bypass uses the same soft-touch footswitch as the Mini Glitch pedal. There's no resistance and no audible click when pressing the footswitch, making it nicer to use barefoot or tabletop. Flexible bypass lets you choose between latching and momentary functionality just by tapping or holding the footswitch. Tapping the footswitch once will turn it on or off (latching). But you can also hold down the footswitch, and it will stay active until you release the footswitch (momentary). Momentary is great for when you want short bursts of distortion, especially if you're using a high gain sound with a lot of noise. In addition, the footswitches are now connected with a simple JST connector, so if there's an issue they can be easily replaced by hand, no soldering needed.

Clipping Modes

The Oxford Drive V2 offers three clipping modes. The mode marked "Si" uses silicone diodes to clip the signal. They are the "stock" setting, and gives a standard, compressed distortion sound. The mode marked "LED" uses a pair of red LEDs to clip the signal, inspired by the Gubenatorial pedal that also used red LEDs for clipping. These LEDs are inside the pedal, and don't relate to the bypass indicator LED. Red LEDs clip at a higher voltage than Silicone diodes. This gives a more "open" distortion sound with less clipping more output volume available. The mode marked "asym" uses one silicone diode and one red LED. Due to the wide difference in clipping thresholds between LEDs and silicone diodes, the "asym" mode has plenty of dynamic range, but still provides the warm, fat sound associated with asymmetrical clipping. The differences between the LED and asym modes are most noticeable at medium gain.

Voice Modes

The Oxford Drive V2 offers two "voice" modes. The '91 voicing is identical to past versions of the Oxford Drive, emulating a Shred-tastic distortion pedal from 1991. The '88 mode has a brighter tone, based on the Gubenatorial drive pedal from 1988. Some other shredder derivatives have a bright switch, but on those pedals the switch only adjusted the output filter, which lets through harsh upper frequencies. On the Oxford Drive, the '88 mode also adjusts the input filter to mitigate any harshness. The result is a really crisp sound, perfect for rhythm playing. By adjusting the voice switch and the clipping switch, you can explore the shades between the two classic drive pedals. The possibilities are particularly expansive when you consider that the contour control is much more powerful than the mids control that came stock on the '88 pedal.

Controls

Clipping Switch

Selects between three diode clipping modes: Silicone, LED, and an asymmetrical hybrid of the two. More info below.

Voice Switch

Selects between two EQ responses for the pedal, adjusting both input and output filters. '91 is taken from a Shredmaster, while '88 is taken from a Guvnor. More info below.

Bass Knob

Controls the level of bass frequencies. This knob has a logarithmic curve, so to get the bass reduction of standard (non-transparent) overdrives you'll want to set the knob between 7 o'clock and 9 o'clock.

Contour Knob

Not a *mid* control. Contour controls the overall EQ shape of the pedal, adjusting both the treble and mid frequencies. More mids and less treble to the left, less mids and more treble to the right.

Treble Knob

Controls the level of treble frequencies. The amount of treble is highly dependent on the setting of the contour control, so the treble control will likely need to be readjusted when the contour control is adjusted.

Gain Knob

Controls the level of distortion. The "stock" maximum gain setting is around 4 o'clock.

Volume Knob

Controls overall volume of the pedal. Unity volume is around noon, but depends upon the gain setting and clipping mode. A large boost is available, so be careful when selecting a high setting, especially in the LED-clipping mode.

Footswitch

The soft-touch footswitch controls a mechanical relay for true-bypass operation. You can get latching bypass by tapping the switch, or momentary bypass by holding down switch. Both are true-bypass.

The default bypass state of the pedal can be selected by holding down the footswitch while the pedal powers on. Doing so will flip the default state.

Recommended Settings

For all of these settings, set volume to taste.

Also note that the gain and volume controls offer extended range compared to an original 90s pedal.

Traditional 90s Lead

Voice: '91
Clipping: Silicone ("Si")
Gain: 3 o'clock
Bass: 2 o'clock
Contour: 7 o'clock
Treble: 2 o'clock

Warm Blues Lead

Voice: '91
Clipping: LED
Bass: 12 o'clock
Contour: 7 o'clock
Treble: 8 o'clock
Gain: 2 o'clock

Dynamic 90s Rhythm

Voice: '88
Clipping: LED
Gain: 1 o'clock
Bass: 12 o'clock
Contour: 3 o'clock
Treble: 4 o'clock

Low-gain Ambient/Shoegaze

Voice: '91
Clipping: Silicone ("Si")
Bass: 11 o'clock
Contour: 12 o'clock
Treble: 2 o'clock
Gain: 3 o'clock

Works best with dynamic arpeggios or chords and delay/reverb.

Classic Green Overdrive

Voice: '88
Clipping: Silicone ("Si")
Gain: 12 o'clock
Bass: 9 o'clock
Contour: 9 o'clock
Treble: 3 o'clock

For a slightly crunchier, more dynamic "yellow overdrive" sound, use the same settings with asymmetrical clipping.

Scooped High-gain

Voice: '88
Clipping: Silicone ("Si")
Bass: 11 o'clock
Contour: 3 o'clock
Treble: 2 o'clock
Gain: 3 o'clock

To ensure that you still cut through the mix with a scooped setting, you may need to tweak the contour setting to adjust to your amp's mids.

(Recommended Settings. continued.)

Boxy Amp at the Edge of Breakup:

Voice: '88
Clipping: Asymmetrical ("Asym")
Bass: 9 o'clock
Contour: 2 o'clock
Treble: 12 o'clock
Gain: 12 o'clock
Volume: 12 o'clock

This setting will probably only sound good through a clean amp, preferably a Fender-style one with a clear and balanced tone. But it will bring your Twin Reverb closer to a dirty 4-watt combo with a boxy 8-inch-speaker. For more of a "top boost" sound, dial the treble and contour up to 3 o'clock.

Clean "Fat" Mids-Boost

Voice: '88
Clipping: LED
Bass: 7 o'clock
Contour: 12 o'clock
Treble: 3 o'clock
Gain: 9 o'clock
Volume: 3 o'clock

If you've got a tube amp with a jangly and slightly dirty rhythm tone, then this setting should push your amp into a nice fat lead tone that cuts through the mix. Turn up the gain for a more saturated lead.

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